

Get Goods Gratis — Launch Cost Estimate

★ CURRENT RECONCILED ESTIMATE — 2026-08-03

All Get Goods Gratis launch-cost docs use these figures. Where an older number appears anywhere below, this banner supersedes it. (Reflects everything built through 2026-08-03: the scale flywheels + Services page, the opt-in shopping extension, and the one-command cost floor.)

- **Full launch — web PWA + Android + native iOS: ~\$2,900-\$4,000 year-one all-in.** Developer labor is ~\$2,025-\$3,075 (≈ 27-41 hours @ \$75/hr) — deploy, test, and submit only, because every feature ships prebuilt and ON.
- **Shoestring — web PWA + Android (iOS as fast-follow): ~\$2,000-\$2,800.**
- **Hard external cash floor: ~\$139** for all three platforms (Apple \$99/yr + Google Play \$25 + domain ~\$15); ~\$40 shoestring (no Apple fee — the PWA covers iPhone via Safari).
- **Recurring: AI / media / email \$0/mo** on free tiers (locked in by `npm run cost:floor`); hosting ~\$10-30/mo; LLM capped ~\$5-40/mo. **Optional AWS auto-scaling + full load test** adds up to a ~\$3,100-\$4,800 all-in ceiling.
- ★ **DEFINITIVE DEVELOPMENT COST (full scope): \$3,000 = 40 hours @ \$75/hr** — web PWA + Android + native iOS + AWS auto-scaling + the load test + all features ON, nothing omitted. Developer labor only (fixed fees + recurring spend separate). See `DEV-COST-3000-FULL-SCOPE.md` — the single source of truth for the development-cost number; it supersedes any different *labor* figure elsewhere.

Older single figures in these docs (e.g. "\$3,750-\$4,950" or "under \$3,900") predate the kit/automation that trimmed the developer hours; the number above is current.

Posture: everything is ON, up, and running from the get-go — the product ships feature-complete with every flag ON by default and pre-warms its own content, so launch is deploy/test/submit, not build. See `EVERYTHING-ON-FROM-DAY-ONE.md`.

Prepared 2026-07-28 · Brand-new estimate · Figures are planning targets, not quotes

This estimate covers a complete launch of Get Goods Gratis / PlayEarning Nexus — the web PWA plus native Android and iOS apps, with a load test held in reserve. It reflects the platform as it stands today: the AI-generated product catalog, the Facebook-Marketplace-style marketplace, serverless-GPU catalog imagery, country-by-country localization (currency, language, and flag), welcome rewards, the Daily Boost perk, and Affirm buy-now-pay-later for real goods. The headline point is that the newer capabilities ship prebuilt and switched off by default, so they add almost nothing to what it costs to get live.

One-time development

Development is billed at \$75/hour. The launch kit exists specifically to remove rework — the thing that otherwise drives the high end — by scripting the deploy, validation, and test steps a developer would otherwise perform by hand.

Work item	Hours	Note
Accounts & API keys	0 billable	Owner-completed from the keys worksheet
Deploy backend + Postgres + scheduler	6-8	Single service, auto-migrating, inline scheduler
Pre-deploy validation	1-2	Scripted (<code>validate.sh</code>)
Deploy frontend (same origin)	2-3	Served by the backend
Configure AI / catalog	1-2	Environment only — no code, features prebuilt
Card payments sandbox → live	0-8	Optional; card is off by default
Survey / earn-loop test	4-6	End-to-end earning path
QA pass	7-9	Against the QA test plan
Android submission (signed .aab)	10-13	Android submission kit
iOS submission (cloud CI, no Mac needed)	5-9	iOS-without-a-Mac kit
Total	~36-52 hours	≈ \$2,700-\$3,900

Keeping card payments off at launch holds you near the low end — roughly 36-40 hours, or about \$2,700-\$3,000. The AI,

catalog, and marketplace features add only one to two hours of configuration because they are already built and default to off.

Ongoing runtime (monthly)

Item	Cost
Hosting (single instance to start)	~\$10-30/mo
Catalog images (one-time, all countries)	~\$9-15 once
LLM text — catalog seed, assistant, optimization	Capped; ~\$5-40/mo by usage
Geo-IP + exchange rates	Free tier
Domain and store fees	Domain \$12-15/yr · Apple \$99/yr · Play \$25 once
Realistic month one	~\$25-100 , hard-capped by the daily AI spend limit

Year-one, all-in

"Everything operational" means development plus a full year of actually running the platform. Two honest scenarios:

Bucket	Full (PWA + Android + iOS)	Shoestring (PWA + Android; iOS as fast-follow)
Development (one-time)	\$2,700-\$3,900	\$2,000-\$2,700
One-time fees	Play \$25 + images ~\$15	Play \$25 + images \$0-15
Apple Developer	\$99/yr	\$0 (deferred)
Domain	~\$15/yr	~\$15/yr (or free subdomain)
Hosting (year 1)	~\$120-360	~\$120-180
LLM (year 1, capped)	~\$60-480	~\$60-180
Year-one all-in	~\$3,900-\$4,900	~\$2,300-\$3,100

Development cost is identical across both — the difference is first-year operating cost, not build cost.

The lever that lands "everything operational" near \$3,000

Launch the web PWA and Android now, and add the native iOS app as a fast-follow once revenue covers it. This removes the 5-9 iOS development hours (~\$375-\$675), the \$99/yr Apple fee, and the single biggest budget risk — App Store rejection rounds, which are common for money-earning apps. Crucially, iPhone users are **not** locked out: the PWA installs and runs on iOS Safari, so everyone can use Get Goods Gratis on day one. Because the app is a Capacitor wrapper and the iOS CI config already exists, adding iOS later is a flip, not a rebuild.

Stacking the other levers keeps you at the floor: card and cash-out off (no processor fees), Affirm off until merchant approval (\$0 fixed), images at the ~\$10 posture or text-only at \$0, the daily AI spend cap set low, and a single launch country with a small starting catalog. Everything stays fully functional — just scoped to web + Android at launch — for roughly **\$2,300-\$3,100 all-in in year one**, inside the original ~\$3,000-and-change target.

Keeping all three platforms and every feature on — with AWS auto-scaling

If you want web, Android, and iOS all live with every feature on and AWS paid-tier auto-scaling for reliability, that is achievable at the low end using automation and free-tier levers rather than cutting scope. Auto-scaling infrastructure is a deliberate reliability choice that costs more than a hobby tier, so it lifts the year-one figure above the shoestring number — that trade is intentional.

Bucket	Cost with levers	The lever
Development (one-time)	\$2,000-\$2,600	Prebuilt features (\$0) + scripted deploy/QA collapse phases into commands
Hosting — AWS auto-scaling (year 1)	\$900-1,740	Fargate + ALB + RDS floor ~\$75-145/mo; trim to ~\$40-70/mo with App Runner, single-AZ RDS, and Redis/SQS left off until the load test needs them
LLM (year 1)	\$60-300	Daily spend cap, small-tier models, paced jobs
Images	\$0-15	Text-only launch (\$0) or ~\$10 image posture
Play (one-time)	\$25	—

Apple Developer	\$99/yr	Unavoidable for a native iOS app
Domain	\$12-15	—
Year-one all-in	≈ \$3,100-\$4,800	Everything on, all three platforms, AWS auto-scaling

The honest all-in here is about **\$3,100-\$4,800**, versus ~\$2,300-\$3,000 on a free hosting tier — the gap is almost entirely the auto-scaling infrastructure floor. To pull it back toward \$3,000 while staying on AWS, start with App Runner (auto-scales, no load balancer), single-AZ RDS, and Redis and SQS switched off until a load test proves you need them. That trims hosting to roughly \$40-70/mo and lands year-one near **\$2,900-\$3,600**.

Load test

Deferred until traffic warrants it, so it adds nothing to the launch number. The first pass runs k6 or Artillery from a single box against staging, which is nearly free. A full-scale run uses spot instances spun up and torn down the same day — an hours-long spend, not a standing cost. The scale toggles identify the one knob to turn, so there is no speculative over-provisioning.

Risks to the number

The main wildcard is an **iOS App Store rejection round**, which is common for earn-money apps and adds development hours each time it happens. It is mitigated with a demo login and "merit, not gambling" store framing, but it is the one thing that can push past \$3,000, so budget a small contingency.

Cash-out stays off — not to save money, but for legal reasons: real-money withdrawal triggers money-transmission licensing, a separate and expensive track. Everything else — marketplace, catalog, AI, welcome rewards, Daily Boost, Affirm, and card payments — can be on. This is a compliance guardrail, not a budget cut.

Bottom line

A full PWA + Android + iOS launch runs roughly **\$2,700-\$3,900 in development** with **~\$25-100 in month-one runtime**, and the load test stays deferred and cheap. Year-one all-in lands at about **\$2,300-\$3,100 on the shoestring path**, **~\$3,100-\$4,800 with all three platforms on AWS auto-scaling**, or **near \$3,000 with everything on** using the automation and free-tier levers. The hard floor you cannot code away is about **\$139** — Apple \$99, Play \$25, and a domain around \$15 — with the iOS-review contingency as the only real risk to the number. The AI, catalog, and marketplace capabilities are included at essentially no added launch cost because they ship prebuilt and off by default.